

Document 24C. Evaluation Practice Pack — 10 Prompts, 10 Self-Mark Grids

Purpose. Doc 24B taught you the SPECIES+A framework. This document gives you ten practice prompts spanning every Tier 1 topic, each with: (i) the prompt itself, (ii) a model thesis/antithesis skeleton, (iii) the recommended SPECIES+A picks, (iv) a model evaluation paragraph + synthesis conclusion, (v) a self-mark grid you complete after writing your own version blind.

Use protocol. (1) Cover the model answer. (2) Write the essay in 27 minutes (15-mark) or 45 minutes (25-mark). (3) Reveal the model. (4) Score yourself against the rubric. (5) Re-attempt any prompt scoring < 18/24 within 7 days.

Section . Self-Mark Rubric (Use for Every Prompt)

Score 0–3 per criterion. Target $\geq 18/24$.

#	Criterion	Max	Score
1	Clear thesis with 2–3 developed points	3	
2	Clear antithesis directly challenging the thesis	3	
3	Causal chains (mechanism), not just assertion	3	
4	Singapore-specific evidence with year-tag	3	
5	At least 2 SPECIES+A criteria deployed	3	
6	Explicit assumption challenge (the E3 lever)	3	
7	Synthesis conclusion with binding condition	3	
8	Diagrams fully labelled (axes, curves, equilibria, shaded areas)	3	
Total		24	

Section Prompt 1. Negative Production Externality — Carbon Tax [15]

Question. “Discuss whether the carbon tax is the most effective policy to correct the market failure arising from carbon emissions in Singapore.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: E (alternatives), S (side-effects), A (assumption about MEC measurability).

Thesis skeleton. (1) Pigouvian tax internalises MEC: shifts MPC up to MSC, output moves from Q_m to Q^* , DWL eliminated. (2) Revenue-recycling: S\$25/tCO_{2e} (2024) rising to S\$45 by 2026 funds Green Plan 2030. (3) Price signal incentivises long-run abatement technology.

Antithesis skeleton. (1) PED for carbon-intensive goods is inelastic in SR — limited Q adjustment. (2) Regressive — low-income households disproportionately hit. (3) Carbon leakage — domestic firms may relocate to non-taxing jurisdictions.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The decisive consideration is the efficacy of alternatives (E). Tradable permits (cap-and-trade) directly fix the emissions quantity but require accurate cap-setting and create price volatility. Regulation (mandates on power plants) avoids the price signal but loses dynamic-efficiency incentive. The deeper issue is an assumption challenge (A): the Pigouvian framework assumes the government can measure MEC accurately. In practice, the social cost of carbon is contested — IPCC estimates range from US\$50–200/tCO_{2e}. If Singapore’s tax is set below the true MEC, the market failure is only partially corrected; if above, a new DWL is created on the other side. The side-effect (S) of regressivity is real but mitigated through U-Save rebates funded directly from carbon revenue.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, the carbon tax is the most effective single instrument for Singapore because it is administratively simple, generates revenue for complementary policies, and preserves the price signal that drives long-run technology adoption. This conclusion holds firmly given Singapore’s open economy and small*

carbon footprint, where regulation alone would be insufficient and permits would be too volatile. It would require revision in jurisdictions with deeper carbon-intensive industries where carbon-leakage risk dominates.

Section Prompt 2. Positive Consumption Externality — Vaccination Subsidy [15]

Question. “Assess whether subsidies are the best policy to correct the under-consumption of healthcare services in Singapore.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: E (alternatives — public provision, info campaigns), I (impact on stakeholders), A (rational consumer assumption).

Thesis skeleton. (1) Subsidy shifts MPB up to MSB; equilibrium moves from Q_m to Q^* . (2) Singapore: CHAS subsidies + MediShield Life raise primary care utilisation. (3) Preserves consumer choice unlike direct provision.

Antithesis skeleton. (1) Information failure persists — households don't know full MEB. (2) Fiscal cost rises with population aging. (3) Moral hazard — over-consumption of cheap services.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The effectiveness of subsidies depends on whether the underlying cause is purely externality or includes information failure (A: rational consumer assumption). If consumers systematically underestimate MPB — as behavioural economics suggests for preventive care — a subsidy lowers price but does not correct the misperception. In that case, info campaigns + mandatory screening (HPB protocols) yield higher take-up per dollar than subsidies alone. Comparing alternatives (E), direct provision (polyclinics) guarantees access but may stifle competition; subsidies preserve choice but require accurate MEB calibration. The impact on stakeholders (I) is broadly progressive: subsidies disproportionately benefit lower-income groups for whom price elasticity is highest.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, subsidies are not the single best instrument but the central pillar of an effective policy mix — combining subsidies (CHAS) with mandatory enrolment (MediShield Life), info campaigns (HPB), and selective public provision (polyclinics). This conclusion holds because healthcare failure is multi-source (externality, info, equity), and no single instrument addresses all three.*

Section Prompt 3. Market Structure — Monopoly and Consumer Welfare [15]

Question. “Discuss whether consumers in Singapore benefit when a market is dominated by a single firm.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: S (SR allocative vs LR dynamic trade-off), E (extent — contestability), A (assumption of profit reinvestment).

Thesis (harms). (1) $P > MC$ at profit-max output: allocative inefficiency, DWL. (2) X-inefficiency: no competitive pressure. (3) Consumer surplus loss to producer surplus.

Antithesis (benefits). (1) EOS: large firm achieves lower LRAC than fragmented industry. (2) Dynamic efficiency: supernormal profits fund R&D. (3) Natural monopoly case: duplication wasteful (utilities).

Model evaluation paragraph. *The SR allocative loss vs LR dynamic gain trade-off (S) is the heart of the question. The dynamic case rests on an assumption (A) that supernormal profits will actually be reinvested rather than distributed as dividends or wasted on X-inefficient management. Empirically this is uncertain. The extent of harm depends on contestability (E): if entry barriers are low (e.g. e-commerce platforms), the monopolist faces hit-and-run entry threat and behaves competitively even alone. If barriers are structural (network effects, patents, regulated franchises like SP Group), the harm dominates. Singapore's CCCS provides ex-post discipline (Grab-Uber 2018 merger, fined S\$13m) but cannot replicate competitive market structure.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, consumers benefit only when the monopoly is either contestable or directly regulated. For natural monopolies (PUB, SP Group), price-cap regulation preserves EOS gains while limiting allocative harm. For non-natural monopolies, structural intervention (CCCS) is justified. The conclusion is therefore not a blanket verdict but contingent on the source of the firm's market power.*

Section Prompt 4. AD-AS — Multiplier and Fiscal Stimulus [15]

Question. “Assess the effectiveness of fiscal policy in raising national income in Singapore.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: E (extent — multiplier size), C (cost / sustainability), A (crowding-out assumption).

Thesis. (1) $\Delta G \rightarrow \Delta AD \rightarrow k\Delta Y$; multiplier amplifies. (2) Singapore Resilience Budget 2020: S\$100bn fiscal support, GDP rebounded 7.6% in 2021. (3) Targeted (JSS) preserves employment in worst-hit sectors.

Antithesis. (1) Singapore $k \approx 0.5\text{--}0.7$ vs $1.5\text{--}2.0$ in large closed economies. (2) Implementation lag. (3) Balanced-budget norm constrains permanent expansion.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The standard multiplier analysis assumes (A) closed economy and no crowding out — both violated for Singapore. Trade-to-GDP >300% creates massive import leakage; CPF mandates high MPS; MAS-managed S\$ means fiscal expansion need not raise r , removing the textbook crowding-out channel but introducing imported-inflation pressure instead. The extent (E) of the multiplier is therefore structurally small. The cost (C) dimension favours fiscal: NIRC funding makes one-off fiscal expansion sustainable without debt accumulation, unlike most economies. The binding constraint is therefore not crowding out but capacity — once near full employment, fiscal expansion is inflationary not output-expanding.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, fiscal policy is effective as a counter-cyclical tool in severe recessions (2020) but a weak engine for raising trend Y . This conclusion is conditional on the binding constraint being demand (where fiscal works) rather than supply (where supply-side investment dominates).*

Section Prompt 5. Inflation — Cost-Push and MAS Policy [15]

Question. “Discuss whether exchange rate appreciation is the most effective response to cost-push inflation in Singapore.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: E (source of inflation), S (side-effects on exports), A (passthrough assumption).

Thesis. (1) Stronger S\$ lowers import prices directly (pass-through ~ 0.4 on headline CPI). (2) Used April + October 2022 to combat imported inflation from Ukraine war. (3) Faster transmission than fiscal restraint.

Antithesis. (1) Cannot address purely domestic cost shocks. (2) Hurts export competitiveness in LR. (3) If global rivals also tighten, real ER barely moves.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The case rests on the assumption (A) that exchange-rate pass-through is high and stable — empirically validated for Singapore but not for closed economies. The decisive consideration is the source of inflation (E): if cost-push is externally-imported (energy, food), appreciation reduces the shock directly. If cost-push is domestic (wage push), appreciation does nothing and may even amplify the squeeze by reducing export revenue. The side-effect (S) on exporters is real but mitigated in practice by productivity policies (PSG, RIE2025) that preserve real competitiveness even as nominal S\$ rises.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, MAS appreciation is the most effective response to externally-imported cost-push inflation, complemented by targeted fiscal transfers (GST Vouchers, CDC vouchers 2022) to cushion vulnerable households. This conclusion would not generalise to economies without high pass-through or to inflation episodes driven by domestic wage push.*

Section Prompt 6. Unemployment — Structural vs Cyclical Policy [15]

Question. “Assess whether supply-side policies are more effective than demand-side policies in reducing unemployment in Singapore.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: E (type of unemployment), S (SR vs LR), A (skills-mismatch assumption).

Thesis (SS more effective). (1) Singapore's structural unemployment dominates — skills mismatch from automation, AI, offshoring. (2) SkillsFuture (2015) + ITE redesign address root cause. (3) Demand-side hits capacity constraint at $\sim 2\%$ headline rate.

Antithesis (DS still needed). (1) Cyclical unemployment in recessions (3.5% peak 2020) needs immediate stimulus. (2) Supply-side has 5–10 year gestation. (3) JSS 2020 preserved employment effectively.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The supply-side case rests on an assumption (A) that retraining successfully bridges skills gaps. Empirically, mid-career retraining has variable success — workers above 50 with low base education show weaker employment outcomes post-SkillsFuture. The relevant frame is therefore SR vs LR (S):*

demand-side (JSS, fiscal transfers) is the only feasible cyclical response, while supply-side is the only effective structural response. They are not substitutes but complements addressing different unemployment types (E).

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, supply-side policies dominate in steady state for Singapore because the bulk of residual unemployment is structural, not cyclical. However, this dominance is conditional on the economy being near full employment — in a deep recession (2020-style), demand-side policies regain primacy.*

Section Prompt 7. Economic Growth — Sustained vs Inclusive [25]

Question. “Discuss the policies the Singapore government should adopt to achieve sustained and inclusive economic growth.” [25]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: P (priorities — growth vs equity), S (SR vs LR), I (impact on income groups), A (trickle-down assumption).

Thesis skeleton. (1) Supply-side: R&D (RIE2025), SkillsFuture, FDI attraction. (2) Demand-side: counter-cyclical fiscal in downturns. (3) Distributional: ProgressivePackage, Workfare, CPF top-ups for inclusiveness.

Antithesis skeleton. (1) Skill-biased technological change concentrates gains (Gini rose 0.43→0.48 then back to 0.44). (2) FDI-led growth captures profits abroad. (3) Carbon-intensive growth conflicts with sustainability.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The deepest issue is an assumption (A): does productivity-led growth “trickle down”? Empirically in Singapore, before-transfer Gini suggests it does not — the top quintile has captured a disproportionate share of growth since 2000. Sustained and inclusive growth are therefore not automatically compatible; achieving both requires explicit redistributive policy alongside the growth engine. The priority conflict (P) between aggregate Y growth and distributional equity is real. The time-horizon split (S) matters: supply-side raises LRAS over 5–10 years, while inclusive policies (Workfare, ProgressivePackages) act on annual timescales. The impact on stakeholders (I) is structurally uneven; the policy challenge is to engineer compensation, not assume it.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, sustained and inclusive growth requires a four-lever policy mix: (1) supply-side investment to raise potential growth, (2) targeted redistribution (Workfare, ProgressivePackage) to share the gains, (3) sustainability instruments (carbon tax to S\$45 by 2026) to avoid environmental drawdown, and (4) counter-cyclical fiscal capacity (NIRC, reserves) for resilience. The conclusion is conditional on policy coordination — no single lever achieves all three growth dimensions, and a government prioritising aggregate growth alone will produce sustained but un-inclusive outcomes.*

Section Prompt 8. Balance of Payments — Depreciation and CA [15]

Question. “Assess whether exchange rate depreciation is an effective way to correct a current account deficit.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: S (SR J-curve vs LR), E (extent — elasticities), A (Marshall-Lerner assumption).

Thesis. (1) Depreciation makes X cheaper, M dearer; CA improves if M-L holds. (2) Avoids contractionary fiscal/monetary. (3) Market-determined under flexible regime.

Antithesis. (1) J-curve: CA worsens before improving. (2) Imported inflation. (3) Retaliatory depreciation by trading partners.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The thesis rests on the Marshall-Lerner assumption (A): $|PED_X| + |PED_M| > 1$. For commodity importers, PED_M for essential imports is inelastic in SR. For Singapore specifically, ~100% of energy and most food is imported — PED_M near zero, so depreciation generates large inflation with limited M reduction. The time horizon (S) split is decisive: SR worsens via J-curve, LR depends on M-L. The extent (E) of correction depends on the deficit's source — if the CA deficit is cyclical (recession-driven), it self-corrects; if structural (loss of comparative advantage), only supply-side reform restores the trade balance.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, depreciation is at best a SR palliative, not a sustainable CA solution, and is particularly ill-suited for Singapore where M elasticity is structurally low and imported inflation costs are high. This explains MAS's consistent preference for appreciation over depreciation. The conclusion holds firmly for small-open commodity-importing economies and would generalise to other commodity-importer cases.*

Section Prompt 9. International Trade — Protectionism and Welfare [15]

Question. “Discuss whether tariffs are ever justified for a small open economy.” [15]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: S (side-effects — retaliation), E (alternatives — subsidy, retraining), A (infant-industry commitment problem).

Thesis. (1) Infant-industry: temporary protection while EOS achieved. (2) National security: strategic sectors. (3) Anti-dumping: prevent predatory pricing.

Antithesis. (1) Welfare cost — consumer DWL and production DWL. (2) Retaliation. (3) Infant industries rarely “grow up”.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The infant-industry case rests on an assumption (A) that the government can credibly commit to remove the tariff once the industry matures. Empirically this commitment is rarely credible — protected producers lobby successfully to retain protection, and temporary tariffs become permanent. The side-effect (S) of retaliation is severe in a small-open economy: Singapore has no domestic market to fall back on. The alternative (E) of a production subsidy is strictly more efficient — it raises domestic output without distorting consumer prices, eliminating the consumption DWL — though at fiscal cost. Combined with retraining (SkillsFuture) for displaced workers from import-competing sectors, the subsidy-plus-retraining combination dominates a tariff on welfare grounds.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, tariffs are almost never welfare-justified for a small open economy because the alternatives (subsidy, retraining, FTAs) dominate on efficiency and avoid retaliation. The conclusion holds firmly given the Singapore openness ratio >300%; would require revision only for narrow national-security cases where domestic capability is non-negotiable.*

Section Prompt 10. Globalisation — Net Benefit Evaluation [25]

Question. “Discuss whether Singapore has benefited from globalisation.” [25]

Recommended SPECIES+A picks: E (existential dependence), I (differential stakeholder impact), S (vulnerability to shocks), A (counterfactual assumption).

Thesis. (1) GDP per capita US\$12k (1990) to US\$65k (2023). (2) FTAs (USSFTA, EUSFTA, RCEP, CPTPP) expand markets. (3) FDI inflows: technology transfer, employment. (4) Consumer surplus from competition.

Antithesis. (1) Vulnerability: 2020 contraction 5.4% from external shock. (2) Inequality: before-transfer Gini rose 0.43→0.48. (3) Structural unemployment from offshoring. (4) Imported inflation 2022.

Model evaluation paragraph. *The benefit question rests on an implicit assumption (A) that there is a viable counterfactual — a less-globalised Singapore. There is not: a resource-scarce island of 5.9m cannot feed, fuel, or employ itself in autarky. The extent (E) of dependence is therefore existential, and the policy question is not whether to be open but whether openness is well-managed. The impact on stakeholders (I) is the operative dimension: consumers and high-skilled workers gained disproportionately; low-skilled workers bear structural costs. Singapore’s response — SkillsFuture, Workfare, ProgressivePackage — explicitly acknowledges that openness requires distributional management. The side-effect (S) of external vulnerability is real but mitigated by FTA diversification (no single market exceeds 15% of trade) and reserves accumulation.*

Synthesis conclusion. *On balance, Singapore has benefited substantially and inevitably from globalisation; the structural alternative does not exist. The conclusion holds firmly given decades of redistributive and skills policies that have prevented the worst distributional consequences. It would require qualification for larger, self-sufficient economies where the openness-vulnerability trade-off is genuinely two-sided and where less-globalised paths are feasible.*

Section . Practice Schedule Recommendation

Week 1. Prompts 1, 2 (micro market-failure). Time 27 min each.

Week 2. Prompts 3 (market structure), 4 (multiplier).

Week 3. Prompts 5 (inflation), 6 (unemployment).

Week 4. Prompts 7 (growth, 25-mark, time 45 min), 8 (BOP).

Week 5. Prompts 9 (trade), 10 (globalisation 25-mark).

Week 6. Re-attempt any prompt scoring < 18/24. Track scores in Doc 33 Topic Tracker.

Final discipline. A practice essay without a self-mark is wasted effort. The score itself is less important than the diagnostic — which row of the rubric scored lowest is the row that will cost you the grade. Re-attempt those rows.